Federation Council, unveiled a joint plan to build the Okhta Business Centre, or 'Gazprom City', where Gazprom Neft was due to relocate permanently after the works were finally completed (Kommersant 2006). It was a project of Babylonian proportions, and its phallic centrepiece was a super-tall skyscraper, which, when erected, would rise over 400 metres into the air, tearing deep into the skyline of a city in which regulations limited the height of any building to a fourth of that. In the place of an appropriate compensation for the inconvenience, Sibneft/Gazprom Neft pledged to pay the local authorities an annual sum of RUB20 billion in local taxes for the citizens' inconvenience. The sum amounted to roughly half of the annual budget for the Leningrad Oblast. By contrast, building the Okhta Centre was expected to cost well over RUB120 billion (almost US$5 billion). The property rights were to be distributed accordingly, once the exact dues of the city administration and gas company are established (Novaia Gazeta 2009). Local residents continued to protest against the development. During 2009 and throughout 2010, pressure mounted on both Gazprom Neft and Matviyenko, until finally, in December 2010, Matviyenko announced that at least the skyscraper would be relocated to some other part of the city (Shakirova 2010).

The story, in itself anecdotal, speaks of Russia's official geopolitical resurgence, built with the energy profits lying at the heart of its new-found (long-sought) great-power status and through the 'power vertical' erected by Putin at home. Just as the old Sankt-Peterburg was the vision and legacy of Peter the Great, a 'Gazprom City' on the Neva testified to Putin's successful restoration programme, very much in the same way as the postmodern monumentality lifted at Sochi for the Winter Olympics in 2014 – including, in this last case, losses through embezzlement perhaps worth as much US$30 billion, according to the assessment offered by the erstwhile deputy Prime Minister turned opposition figure, Boris Nemtsov, murdered in Moscow as this book was going into press (see Nemtsov 2014). The Okhta Centre, just like Sochi or the more recent 'greater Moscow' projects, was meant to showcase Russia's confident entrance into the 21st century not only as a global power but as an international business hub (Golubchikov 2010; see also Pozo-Martin 2013). But what they display, and this remains particularly true of the Okhta Centre, is of deeper significance. Indeed, Gazprom's takeover of Sibneft, the economic event behind the architectural project, was the very embodiment of Putin's wide-ranging programme for the political and economic reorganisation of Russia along clear corporatist lines. His ambitious plan included a new federal set-up able to bring the regions under direct control from the Kremlin, the crackdown on independent media (television in particular), a substantial shake-up of the electoral and party systems, and finally,